



Plants for productive patios

The beauty of a sunny patio is that you can combine flowers with ornamental crops to produce delicious displays that taste as good as they look.

Many crops are happy to live in pots, especially tropical types, such as chili peppers, tomatoes, and eggplants, which need a sheltered, hot spot for their fruits to ripen. Dwarf and miniature fruit trees can also thrive here, given large containers and plenty of water; consider installing an automatic watering system to ensure a constant supply. Fruits in pots also benefit from regular feeding. Pots provide the perfect habitat for leafy salads, too—container cultivation makes it easier to protect their leaves against marauding pests—while potatoes, beans, and peas will thrive in big tubs.



BULB MEDIUM

Chives

Allium schoenoprasum A perennial bulb with hollow, grassy dark green mild onion-flavored leaves, which can be used in salads and other dishes. It bears pale purple or pink pom-pom flowers in summer. Suitable for containers and windowboxes.

↑12in (30cm)

☞ Z4–8



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Beet

Beta vulgaris Sown from seed in spring and summer, this sweet-tasting earthy root can be harvested as soon as it reaches a good size. It has attractive stems and leaves, and looks good in decorative container displays.

↑9in (23cm) ↔18in (45cm)



SHRUB LARGE

Lemon verbena

Aloysia triphylla This shrub has spear-shaped leaves that smell and taste of lemon, and can be used to make tea or to flavor sweet dishes. In summer, it bears spikes of small white flowers. Grow it in a large container; protect from hard frosts.

↑↑10ft (3m)

☞ Z8–11



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Swiss chard

Beta vulgaris Grown from seed in spring, this crop produces large glossy green leaves, which can be used raw in salads or steamed, and fleshy stems that are best cooked. Harvest plants lightly throughout summer, and water regularly.

↑↑18in (45cm)



BULB MEDIUM

Onion

Allium cepa This onion crop can be planted as sets or seed during spring, and harvested from mid- to late summer. Lift and dry the bulbs once the tops bend over. Plant in large pots and growing bags in a sunny position.

↑24in (60cm)



BULB MEDIUM

Spring onion

Allium cepa This small onion is sown from seed from spring to fall, and is ready to harvest in 6–8 weeks. It is ideal for containers and windowboxes placed in a sunny position. White- and red-stemmed varieties (above) are available.

↑10in (25cm) when harvested



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL LARGE

Chinese spinach

Amaranthus tricolor This upright plant is raised from seed and grown for its leaves, which can be used in salads or left to flower and harvested for its edible seeds, which are used as grain. Add this colorful plant to decorative displays.

↑4½ft (1.4m) ↔18in (45cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL MEDIUM

Celeriac

Apium graveolens Sown from seed in spring, this crop bears large swollen roots, with a nutty, celery-like flavor. Harvest in fall or in summer as baby roots. Best in large pots. In zones 7 and higher, plant it in summer for a fall, winter, or spring crop.

↑3ft (1m) ↔18in (45cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Mustard greens

Brassica juncea This crop is grown for its peppery-tasting leaves. Sow seeds in spring and summer, and harvest the plant young as “cut-and-come-again” leaves, or let mature. Grow in windowboxes and pots; water well. Considered invasive in some areas.

↑↑12in (30cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Kohlrabi

Brassica oleracea var. gongylodes This crop is grown for its nutty-tasting swollen stems that mature in as little as six weeks. Sow seeds in repeated batches in growing bags and containers in early spring or fall, and harvest when large enough.

↑↑18in (45cm)

